

Kindergarten Parent Guide

Cypress Springs Elementary | First-Day Family Handout

A practical guide for new kindergarten families who want to stay informed, get involved, and know where to find help.

Start Here: The 5 Most Important Things to Do

1) Download and activate ParentSquare. 2) Complete ADDitions if you plan to volunteer or chaperone. 3) Join the CSE PTA and PTA Facebook group. 4) Bookmark the CSE school website and PTA shop/calendar. 5) Watch ParentSquare and the PTA calendar for CSE and PTA events, field trips, spirit days, photo days, deadlines, and event signups.

Quick Links for Parents

Use these to confirm you are on the correct school, OCPS, PTA, or payment page.

CSE School Website

School news, calendar, staff, resources, and volunteer information



Scan to open

ADDitions Volunteer Application

Required for volunteering and many on-campus activities



Scan to open

ParentSquare Sign-In

Sign in with the email or phone number connected to your OCPS/Skyward account



Scan to open

CSE PTA Website

PTA memberships, spirit items, and school merchandise



Scan to open



CSE PTA Facebook Group

PTA parent group



Scan to open

MealViewer Menu

Breakfast and lunch menus



Scan to open

OCPS ParentSquare Information

OCPS information about ParentSquare and the mobile app



Scan to open

2026–2027 OCPS/CSE Calendar

District school calendar



Scan to open

First Week Checklist

The goal is to make sure you receive information, know the process, and can participate when opportunities come up at Cypress Springs Elementary.

- ParentSquare: Download the app, activate your account, and check notification settings. Most school and teacher communication will come through ParentSquare.
- SchoolCash/Payments: Use the school website link for SchoolCash when paid items or events are announced.
- ADDitions Volunteer Approval: Complete the ADDitions application early. Do not skip the video step.
- Calendar: Check the CSE school calendar, ParentSquare posts, and the PTA calendar for CSE and PTA events, field trips, spirit days, photo days, deadlines, and event signups.
- PTA Membership: Join the PTA through the CSE PTA Website.
- ID: Keep your government-issued photo ID with you any time you come to campus.

School Day Basics

- School hours: 8:45 a.m. to 3:00 p.m. Monday, Tuesday, Thursday, and Friday. Most Wednesdays are early-release days, with dismissal at 2:00 p.m.
- If your child arrives after 8:45 a.m., check in through the front office.
- If you need to pick up early, drop off an item, or speak with the front office, bring a valid government-issued photo ID.
- CSE generally does not allow early checkouts during the last 30 minutes of the school day so dismissal procedures can run safely.
- All dismissal changes must be submitted in writing through ParentSquare or email. Late dismissal changes should be called in to the front office.
- Follow all posted traffic signs in the parking lot. Left turns into and out of the CSE parking lot are not allowed.
- 30/30 Lightning Rule: If lightning is detected during dismissal, dismissal may be delayed 30 minutes to release students. Please be patient and follow school instructions.
- Absences may be approved for illness, religious holidays, doctor's appointments, or legal appointments. Absences for other reasons require a preapproval form, available from the front office.

Communication: Where to Look First and School Apps

- ParentSquare: Primary school communication tool. Watch for teacher posts, school updates, emergency notices, event information, and reminders.
- PTA Facebook Group: Useful for reminders and parent-to-parent visibility, but always confirm formal dates and procedures through official school/PTA communication.
- Room Parent Emails: If your class has one or more room parents, make sure your teacher has the email addresses you want included on the classroom BCC list.
- CSE offers a wide range of online apps for continued learning, digital reading, and tracking reading minutes. Ask your teacher about your child's app options and login information.

ParentSquare Tip

If ParentSquare is not working, confirm your email address and phone number in Skyward/OCPS records and contact the front office for help. ParentSquare uses contact information connected to the school system.

Key People to Learn

- Kindergarten Teachers: Mrs. Morrison, Mrs. Portalatin, and Ms. Valentin
- Principal: Mrs. Patriarch
- Vice Principal: Mrs. Rosa
- Resource Officer: Deputy Ochoa
- School Nurse: Mrs. Luz Irizarry, 407-249-6950 (press 4)
- Specials Teachers: Mrs. Bondi for Art, Mrs. Heldstab for Music, Coach Longhouse for PE, and Mrs. Leslie for Media Center/Library
- Extended Day Contact: Ms. Hali Thompson, hali.thompson@ocps.net, 407-249-6950 ext. 3222260
- PTA Contacts: David Nowell, PTA President; Stefanie Preston, PTA Vice President; and Carrie Balthazar, PTA Board Member and Room Parent Leader

Volunteering and Campus Visits

- Complete the free ADDitions approval process before volunteering or chaperoning. Assign yourself to Cypress Springs Elementary after approval.
- Bring a government-issued photo ID each time you visit or volunteer.
- Check in at the front office and wear the visitor/volunteer badge while on campus.
- Some events and lunch visits may require advance signup or approval. Confirm details through ParentSquare or the front office.

PTA and How to Get Involved

- The CSE PTA is a great way to meet other families, build friendships, support our teachers, and strengthen our school community.
- Join the CSE PTA through the PTA website. Parents, guardians, grandparents, aunts, uncles, and other adult family members can join.
- Current CSE students may receive free entry to some PTA member events when an active adult CSE PTA family member is on file and attends the event. Confirm event rules before each event.
- Support your teacher by purchasing a teacher membership when available.
- Volunteer for events, attend PTA meetings, help your room parent, or assist with donations and event setup.
- Buy CSE spirit merchandise through the CSE PTA Website.

Food, Lunch, Extended Day, and After-School Activities

- Breakfast and lunch are offered at no charge for CSE students. Check MealViewer for the daily menu.
- ADDitions-approved parents may be able to have lunch with their child during the assigned lunch period, but school procedures apply. Confirm the current process with the front office.
- Lunch visits may require ADDitions approval, advance reservation, valid photo ID, and authorized-contact status in the student file.
- CSE offers paid before/after Extended Day. Slots may fill quickly and waitlists may apply.
- Check ParentSquare for the club brochure outlining club opportunities available at CSE. Visit the front office for information about additional paid opportunities offered by approved outside providers.

Photo, Media, Yearbook, and Birthday Items

- Complete the Parent Technology Media and Information Consent Form so the school knows whether your child may be photographed, recorded, or included in school/district media.
- Watch ParentSquare and the PTA calendar for photo days. There are usually student photo opportunities during the school year, and class photos may occur later in the year.
- Submit yearbook photos when the school/PTA shares the upload link.
- Yearbooks are typically sold near the end of the school year. Watch for the purchase link.
- The outdoor Happy Birthday banner will be available for the 2026-2027 school year. Reservation details and the current link will be shared once available.

Kindergarten-Specific Tips

- Purchase the kindergarten class shirt if offered. Each class may have a different color, and the shirt may be used for field trips, special days, and end-of-year events.
- Kindergarten usually has field trips. ADDitions-approved parent chaperones may be requested.

- Sight words are important. Practice throughout the year. In kindergarten, students work on reading them; in first grade, students may need to read and write them.
- Kindergarten has homework and testing throughout the year. Teachers will share details.
- Ask your kindergarten teacher for a first-name class list if available. This helps with names, friendships, gifts, and invitations.
- Kindergarten has an end-of-year performance. It is not a graduation, but it is a meaningful milestone.
- Some classes may use a daily behavior color chart or similar system. Ask your teacher what system will be used this year.
- Treasure box donations are often appreciated if the teacher uses a reward box.

Support and Classroom Needs

- If you think your child may need extra support, ask your teacher or the front office about CSE support services, including ESE and gifted services.
- Teachers and specials teachers may have wish lists for classroom supplies. Ask how you can help.

Room Parent Guide: What Room Parents Often Help With

- Create a classroom BCC email list with teacher approval. Copy the teacher and Carrie, the PTA Room Parent Lead, when appropriate.
- Send reminders about school events, classroom activities, teacher requests, donations, and deadlines.
- Use signup tools for voluntary supplies, party items, teacher appreciation needs, and classroom basket donations.
- Help organize voluntary donations for teacher and specials-teacher birthdays, classroom snacks, birthday supplies, treasure-box items, and field-trip needs.
- Decorate your teacher's door for Red Ribbon Week.
- Help with Basket Night/Silent Auction classroom baskets and classroom-party contributions.
- Encourage yearbook photo uploads when the official upload link is provided.

Events to Watch For

Dates and details change. Confirm all events through ParentSquare, the CSE calendar, and the PTA calendar.

Event	What to Know
Photo Days	Watch the PTA calendar and ParentSquare
Book Fairs	Dates vary
Teach-In	ADDITIONS-approved parents may present about their jobs
Red Ribbon Week	Room parents often help with door decorating Theme days and school activities
Trunk or Treat	Organized by PTA Candy/trinket donations and decorated trunks may be requested
APEX Fundraiser	Organized by PTA
Field Day	Organized by PE
Field Trips	Organized by teachers and CSE
Talent Show	Watch for audition and performance details
Cultural/Heritage Night	Table participation may be available
Basket Night/Silent Auction	Classroom baskets and auction donations requested
STEAM Night	School/PTA event; details vary
Teacher Appreciation Week	Room parents often help with decorating and gifts
Literacy Week	Organized by CSE
School Performances	Watch for drama musical and spring concert details
PTA Family Events	Bike Night, movie night, ice cream, bowling, skating, and dances

Favorite Kindergarten Memories to Expect

- A self project using items from home
- Color days where students wear a specific color to help learn colors
- A pumpkin project; tip: fake pumpkins are lighter for children to carry
- Turkey Trot Parade and dress-up project, along with a Thanksgiving food sampler
- 100 Days of School activities
- Valentine exchange
- Themed dress-up days and classroom parties

Final Note from CSE PTA

We truly love CSE. Become ADDitions approved, join the PTA, stay connected with your teacher and room parent, attend events when you can, upload yearbook photos, and enjoy this special year with your kindergartener.